Chapter 21

Dignity Restored:
Tihar Becomes a Happening Place

THE MEDIA'S FAVOURITE, AND THE MOST POPULARIZED PRISONER OF Tihar Jail, Charles Sobhraj, who had spent around 10 years as an undertrial on various charges, including those pinned on him as a result of his successful escape from jail in 1986 (he was subsequently apprehended and brought back), was very moved by the events taking place there after Kiran Bedi took over:

> It's very, very difficult to bring about changes within the Indian system. It's only someone with a lot of guts who can try to do it. What's happening here is very important and I think it should be shared with others. Not just in India but abroad also.
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> I feel what is happening here is that an element of the prisoners' dignity is being restored to them. When I first came here I was shocked to see the submissiveness of the prisoners. Specially the poorer ones. They would be perpetually cowering with fear. Now some nobility at least has been restored to them, some dignity. It is this which has made them lay their trust in the prison administration.
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> The IG reached out to the prisoners and established a relationship of mutual trust with them. She looks for positive things to do. Not: stop this, don't do this. But, do this, try that. She seems to believe that there is good in everyone and she is willing to give everybody a chance.
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> So, this way, she's trying the behaviourism method. If you have to change a system then you have to first change the minds of the people. The mind, the spirit and the system were all British here. For them (the British) it was all right as they were a colonial power. But even after independence no changes have been made at all. The Mulla Committee* reforms have been left sleeping. Nobody wanted to do anything.
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> Earlier there was no balance of power. Everything was in the hands of the jail staff. You could get an extra blanket for a hundred rupees; a television in your cell for five hundred. You could get anything, for a price. But now they are all provided as prisoner privileges. So there was a lot of resentment by the lower staff. Their minds had to be conditioned first. The prisoners came later.
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> It's this humaneness that has made these changes possible. The prisoners have gradually become humanized and are free from fear now.
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> Look, each jail has an alarm siren installed in its *deodis*. The wailing of these sirens was a regular feature every three or four days. Fights amongst the prisoners constituted the main reason. Since May 1993 these sirens have not wailed, not once. Get what I mean?

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